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LEARNER GUIDE

For

Customer-Centric Branding and Communication Tactics

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2.0	4 August 2026	Converted in-class activities to case-study/role-play format (scenario, roles, discussion prompts, reflection points) with a richer supporting-visual set; content realigned to a single continuous Nimbus Wellness scenario matching the Case Study assessment.	Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

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How to Use This Guide

This Learner Guide accompanies the WSQ course Customer-Centric Branding and Communication Tactics (TGS-2026061321), conducted by Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd. It supports the Skills Framework Technical Skill & Competency “Brand Management” (ICT-SNM-3002-1.1, Level 3) across 4 Learning Units and 17 in-class activities.

Use this guide alongside the course slides during class, and again during the open-book assessment. Each Learning Unit section below lists the key concepts, followed by every activity you will complete in class as a case study or role play — its scenario, discussion and decision prompts, and a debrief check — rather than a numbered instruction list. This is a workshop-based course rather than a software course, so activities are illustrated with worked templates and examples on the slides rather than software screenshots.

Before you start, you will need:

- A notebook or digital document to capture your activity work.
- Internet access to research live brand examples where an activity calls for one.
- The course slides (downloaded from the LMS) for reference during activities and the assessment.

Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Identify the internal and external stakeholders and audiences who influence the brand, and create branding designs and reputation assessments that reflect the organisation's product or service attributes and benefits.
- LO2: Capture and analyse customer insights through strategic active-listening approaches — understanding customer perceptions of the brand and documenting the reception and outcomes of branding campaigns.
- LO3: Apply branding fundamentals within the marketing mix — executing branding campaigns, events and public-relations activities that increase brand awareness in alignment with brand positioning strategy, operational plans and budget.
- LO4: Evaluate brand and public-relations effectiveness using reputation indicators and KPIs across platforms, and recommend improvements to strengthen public-relations campaign performance.

Skills Framework Reference

- TSC Title: Brand Management
- TSC Code: ICT-SNM-3002-1.1
- Proficiency Level: Level 3

LU1 — Stakeholders and Organisation

Internal & External Stakeholders · Audience Types · Brand Design · Reputation Assessment

Key concepts

- Internal stakeholders (management, employees) and external stakeholders (customers, partners, investors, media) each hold a different level of influence over — and interest in — the brand.
- External audiences segment into customers, partners, investors and media; each needs its own communication approach and message.
- Branding designs and ideas should foreground the product or service's attributes and the concrete benefits they deliver to the audience.
- Assessing an organisation's reputation on social media and other platforms — reviews, mentions, sentiment — is the starting point for every branding decision.

Activity 1 — Stakeholder Influence Mapping (Role Play)

Objective: Identify internal and external stakeholders influencing the brand.

Scenario

Nimbus Wellness Pte Ltd, a 25-person Singapore boutique skincare and wellness brand, is three months from its 5th-anniversary relaunch. The founder has committed to a new sustainable-packaging line as the centrepiece of the relaunch story.

Not everyone is convinced. Retail operations worries the new packaging will raise unit cost and slow reorders. A wellness retail chain that carries Nimbus in 40 outlets wants proof the change won't disrupt supply before it commits fresh shelf space. Meanwhile a vocal community of long-time customers on social media is already asking why Nimbus hasn't "gone green" sooner.

Before the founder locks the relaunch brief, your table must map who genuinely has power and interest in this decision — and design how to bring each group along, not just announce it to them.

You'll produce

A stakeholder Power-Interest map (12 stakeholders) with a matched engagement approach for each quadrant (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **The Founder** — *Goal: Protect the relaunch vision.* Wants sustainability to be the headline story of the anniversary campaign and is impatient with anything that looks like delay.

- **Retail Operations Lead** — *Goal: Protect margin and delivery reliability.* Worried the new packaging supplier will slow reorders right before the relaunch peak season.
- **Retail Partner Buyer** — *Goal: Protect their own shelf-space risk.* Will only commit expanded shelf space once supply reliability through the transition is proven.

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

1. Which 6 internal and 6 external stakeholders matter most to this relaunch decision, and why?
2. Using the Power-Interest Grid, where does each stakeholder sit — and which quadrant deserves your table's limited attention this month?
3. What is each stakeholder's real underlying concern, not just their stated position?
4. What engagement approach — brief, consult or co-design — fits each stakeholder's concern and influence level?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which stakeholder's position surprised you once you heard their actual concern instead of assuming it?
- Did power and interest always move together on your map, or did a low-power/high-interest voice turn out to be worth listening to anyway?
- If the retail partner buyer voiced hesitation publicly tomorrow, how would that change your grid?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a completed Power-Interest map with both internal and external stakeholders placed, and an engagement approach per quadrant that matches the stakeholder's real concern — not just their job title.

Activity 2 — Audience Mapping Workshop (Case Study)

Objective: Recognise the types of external audience and their needs.

Scenario

Nimbus Wellness's 5th-anniversary relaunch has to speak to four very different audiences at once: existing loyal customers who feel the brand has drifted from them, new customers discovering Nimbus while comparing it to a competitor, the wellness retail chain deciding whether to expand shelf space, and the lifestyle press deciding whether the relaunch is even a story worth covering.

The Marketing Lead has one shared relaunch deck for all four groups. Your table's job is to show her, with evidence, why it cannot say the same thing to all four the same way — and what should change for each.

You'll produce

An audience mapping matrix (4 segments) with a tailored key message and primary channel for each (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

5. What does each of the four audience segments actually need to hear to act — not just what Nimbus wants to say?
6. Where do B2C emotional drivers and B2B/partner logic-driven drivers pull the message in different directions?
7. Which channel does each segment genuinely pay attention to, and does the current "one deck" plan reach it?
8. If you only had budget to fully tailor one segment's message this month, which would you choose — and why?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which audience did your table initially lump together with another — and what made you split them apart?
- Was a channel choice driven by what's easy for Nimbus to produce, or by where the audience actually spends attention?
- How would your messaging change if the lifestyle press turned out to be sceptical rather than curious about the relaunch?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a matrix with a tailored key message and a named primary channel for all four segments, and can explain in one sentence why each message differs from the others.

Activity 3 — Brand Attribute Mapping (Case Study)

Objective: Draft branding designs and ideas highlighting the product or service's attributes and benefits.

Scenario

For the relaunch, the founder wants one page that finally settles what Nimbus stands for — because right now the brand isn't described the same way twice. Retail calls it "affordable self-care." Marketing calls it "clean beauty for real skin." Customer Service calls it "the brand that actually replies."

Your table must map Nimbus's hard attributes (the real product facts) and soft attributes (the feelings those facts create) into one brand concept the founder can approve — and that all three teams could say in their own words.

You'll produce

A brand attribute map (3 hard + 3 soft attributes) linked to one approved brand concept line (Duration: 30 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

9. What are three hard attributes (measurable facts) Nimbus can genuinely claim about its skincare range?
10. What soft attribute — the feeling — does each hard attribute actually create, and is it the same feeling Retail, Marketing and Customer Service currently describe?
11. Using Keller's Brand Equity Pyramid, which level is Nimbus weakest at right now: being noticed (Salience), understood (Performance/Imagery), felt (Judgments/Feelings), or trusted enough to be recommended (Resonance)?
12. What single brand concept line could the founder approve that all three teams could restate consistently?

Reflect & Discuss

- Was it harder for your table to agree on the hard attributes or the soft attributes — and why?
- Which pyramid level did your table disagree about the most?
- If a customer only ever experienced Nimbus through a five-minute Customer Service chat, which attribute would that conversation need to prove true?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show 3 hard + 3 soft attributes connected to one brand concept line, and can name the CBBE pyramid level the concept is designed to strengthen.

Activity 4 — Digital Reputation Audit Exercise (Case Study)

Objective: Assess the organisation's reputation on social media and other platforms.

Scenario

Six months ago a competitor's viral campaign pulled attention away from Nimbus Wellness. Since then, engagement has fallen and reviews increasingly say the brand "doesn't feel personal anymore."

Before the founder finalises the relaunch brief, leadership wants a clear-eyed audit of where Nimbus's reputation actually stands today — not where the founder assumes it stands.

You'll produce

A reputation-assessment report (3 platforms) with sentiment breakdown and a response action per theme (Duration: 45 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

13. Which three platforms will actually reveal how customers feel about Nimbus right now — and why those three?
14. Looking at a sample of recent mentions and reviews, what recurring themes sit behind "doesn't feel personal anymore"?
15. How would you categorise the balance of positive, neutral and negative sentiment — and does it match what the founder currently believes?
16. What is the single highest-priority response action leadership should take before the relaunch brief is finalised?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did the sentiment split match what you expected before you actually read the reviews?
- Which recurring theme was hardest to reduce to one line for a leadership summary?
- If "doesn't feel personal anymore" kept appearing after the relaunch too, what would that tell you about the relaunch plan itself?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a platform-by-platform sentiment breakdown, three named recurring themes, and one response action per theme leadership could act on this week.

LU2 — Customer Influence

Customer Perceptions · Brand Reputation · Campaign Reception · Active Listening

Key concepts

- Customers form perceptions of a brand, its products and its services from quality, experience and communication — a gap often exists between what a company believes and what customers actually feel.

- Customers actively shape brand reputation through word-of-mouth, reviews and advocacy — their voice can amplify or damage a brand faster than any paid campaign.
- Documenting customer reception and the outcome of branding campaigns turns anecdotal feedback into evidence for future campaign decisions.
- Active listening — full attention, a structured framework, and paraphrasing without judgement — reveals the customer's true perspective of the organisation.

Activity 5 — Brand Perception Audit (Case Study)

Objective: Assess customer perceptions of the brand, products and services.

Scenario

The Activity 4 reputation audit surfaced one theme again and again: customers say Nimbus Wellness "doesn't feel personal anymore." Marketing's official position is that nothing has changed — the formulas, ingredients and packaging are exactly what they were a year ago. If the product itself hasn't moved, something else has.

A closer look at Customer Service's own numbers hints at where: average reply time has improved since two outlets added self-checkout kiosks and the contact-centre adopted faster chat macros. The technical quality — what the product does — looks unchanged on paper. But the value quality — how it feels to deal with Nimbus — may have quietly slipped underneath the metrics leadership actually tracks.

Before the founder locks the relaunch brief, your table must compare what Marketing believes against what a sample of real customer feedback actually says, and turn the difference into a short, prioritised gap list leadership can act on this week.

You'll produce

A Nimbus perception-gap analysis comparing internal quality metrics with customer feedback, ranking the top 3 gaps with an action for each (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

17. Looking at the Activity 4 findings alongside what Marketing believes internally, where exactly does customer perception diverge from the company's own view of itself?
18. Is the drift really in Technical Quality (the product itself) or in Value Quality (the experience around it) — and what evidence from the audit supports that?
19. What are the top 3 perception gaps your table would put in front of the founder, and which one is most urgent to close before the relaunch brief is finalised?
20. For each gap, what would "closed" actually look like, and which team would need to own fixing it?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your table's top gap turn out to be about the product itself, or about how people are treated when they interact with the brand?
- Was there a gap the data supported that still felt uncomfortable to put in front of the founder — and why?
- If Marketing pushed back and insisted the product is the whole story, what evidence would you point to first?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a gap-analysis table comparing Marketing's internal belief against real customer feedback, with the top 3 perception gaps ranked and one concrete action proposed for each.

Activity 6 — Brand Advocacy Assessment (Case Study)

Objective: Recognise the importance of the customer in influencing brand reputation.

Scenario

Activity 5 traced the perception gap mostly to Value Quality — the feeling of being known — rather than to the product itself. That is, in one sense, good news: it means Nimbus already has the raw material to fix it. The same loyal-customer Facebook community that has been asking "why hasn't Nimbus gone green sooner?" is still active, still buying, and still willing to talk about the brand.

The founder now wants the relaunch to lean on these genuine advocates rather than paid media alone. But the online review picture is mixed — some customers are clearly still delighted, others are the ones driving the "doesn't feel personal anymore" narrative, and a few are firmly on the fence.

Your table's job is to read the available feedback, identify who the real advocates are, and design an advocacy assessment and strategy that strengthens the loop before the anniversary campaign goes live — without ignoring the risk that a negative experience could restart the narrative that hurt Nimbus six months ago.

You'll produce

A customer-advocacy strategy mapped to the Advocacy Loop, with named target metrics and how each will be tracked (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

21. Reading the mixed feedback, which customers are the strongest genuine candidates for an advocacy programme, and what evidence marks them out from a merely satisfied customer?

22. Using the Advocacy Loop, at which stage is Nimbus currently strongest, and at which stage does the loop most often break down before it reaches a new customer?
23. Given that a competitor's viral moment is what hurt Nimbus six months ago, how real is the risk that one bad experience among these advocates could restart the same narrative — and how would you guard against it?
24. What would you actually ask advocates to do for the relaunch, and what would Nimbus need to give them in return for it to feel genuine rather than transactional?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your table pick advocates based on how loudly they post, or on how consistently satisfied they actually are?
- Which stage of the Advocacy Loop did your table find hardest to strengthen with the resources Nimbus realistically has?
- If one of your chosen advocates had a bad experience next week, would your strategy survive it?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show an advocacy strategy mapped onto the Advocacy Loop, naming which customers to engage, what stage of the loop it strengthens, and at least one target metric with how it will be tracked.

Activity 7 — Campaign Documentation Audit (Case Study)

Objective: Document customer reception to the brand and the outcome of branding campaigns.

Scenario

Three months ago, before committing the full relaunch budget, the Marketing Lead quietly piloted a small "Behind the Jar" campaign — a short Instagram Stories series introducing the new sustainable-packaging story to a slice of the loyal-customer community, alongside one boosted post, a short unpaid write-up from a local lifestyle blog, and a supporting post on the Nimbus website.

Nobody kept a single, consistent record of how it performed. Some numbers live in a Marketing team member's spreadsheet, some in a Notion page nobody else can find, and the rest is only in people's memory of "it went pretty well." With the Board wanting proof that the full relaunch campaign works — not just louder impressions — that will not be good enough this time.

Your table's job is to reconstruct what actually happened to the pilot campaign across paid, earned, shared and owned media, and turn it into a documentation framework the team can reuse for the real relaunch three months from now.

You'll produce

A structured PESO-based campaign-reception report for the pilot, with metrics, gaps and a documentation framework the team can reuse for the full relaunch (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

25. Sorting the pilot's activity into Paid, Earned, Shared and Owned media, where did the strongest customer reception actually happen — and does that match where the team spent the most effort?
26. Which pieces of the pilot's story are you missing data for entirely, and how would you close that gap before the full relaunch campaign launches?
27. What documentation framework would you standardise now, so results don't have to be reconstructed from memory again after the real relaunch?
28. Based on the pilot's results, what is the strongest evidence you would put in front of the Board to justify the relaunch's PR budget?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which of the four PESO categories was hardest to find any real data for — and what does that tell you about Nimbus's current documentation habits?
- Did the channel that felt most successful in the room match the channel the numbers actually supported?
- If the Board asked "how do we know this worked?" right now, could your documentation answer them convincingly?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a PESO-sorted reception report for the pilot campaign with at least one metric per media type, the gaps in current data called out honestly, and a reusable documentation framework for the full relaunch.

Activity 8 — Customer Perspective Analysis (Role Play)

Objective: Perform active listening from the customer to understand the customer's perspective of the organisation.

Scenario

Priya has bought from Nimbus Wellness since its first year. Last night she read the same community Facebook thread the Activity 4 audit flagged — customers saying Nimbus "doesn't feel personal anymore" — and she agrees. This morning she calls Customer Service, frustrated, wanting to know why the brand she used to feel loyal to now treats her like any other order number.

The rep taking the call has a real average-handle-time target and a bank of quick-reply macros that would close this call in under two minutes. But leadership has asked every Customer Service call this week to be an active-listening opportunity, not just a resolution — because this exact situation is what the relaunch's active-listening approach will need to prove it can handle.

Your group of three will run this call as a role play, coached in real time against the 3 P's, then turn what was actually said — not just what was resolved — into a documented customer-perspective insight for the relaunch team.

You'll produce

A completed customer-perspective analysis report — the emotion behind the words, a coaching note against the 3 P's, and one actionable insight for the relaunch team (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **The Customer (Priya)** — *Goal: Be heard and taken seriously, not just processed. A five-year loyal customer who feels increasingly like a transaction. She isn't asking for a refund — she wants to know if anyone at Nimbus still cares.*
- **Nimbus Service Rep** — *Goal: Resolve the call by genuinely listening, not by closing it fast.* Under real pressure to keep the call short, but has been told this week that how the call feels matters as much as how quickly it ends.
- **Observer / Coach** — *Goal: Apply the 3 P's framework as a coaching lens on the call.* Says nothing during the role play itself, but tracks exactly where Presence, Patience and Paraphrasing show up — or don't — to coach the Rep afterwards.

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

29. As the call plays out, where does the Rep genuinely apply Presence, Patience and Paraphrasing — and where do they slip back into passive hearing?
30. What emotion is actually behind Priya's words, as distinct from the literal complaint she's making?
31. How would the Observer paraphrase Priya's perspective back in one honest sentence, without judgement and without minimising it?
32. Beyond "the customer was upset," what concrete, actionable insight should this call generate for the relaunch team?

Reflect & Discuss

- As the Customer, at what point in the call did you feel genuinely heard — or feel yourself give up on being heard?

- As the Rep, was it harder to stay patient, or harder to paraphrase without sounding scripted?
- As the Observer, which of the 3 P's was missing most often, and what would you coach first?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a completed customer-perspective analysis that names the emotion behind Priya's words (not just the words themselves), cites a specific moment where a P was applied or missed, and closes with one actionable insight for the relaunch team.

LU3 — Branding in Marketing

Branding Basics · Role in Marketing · Awareness Campaigns · PR Execution

Key concepts

- Branding basics — visual identity, brand values, brand voice and brand guidelines — give a business a consistent, recognisable presence.
- Branding plays a central role in marketing: it builds trust, differentiates from competitors and creates the emotional connection that drives loyalty.
- Executing branding campaigns, events and activities — from social pushes to experiential pop-ups — raises brand awareness across the target audience.
- Public-relations campaigns must align to the brand positioning strategy, the operational plan and the marketing budget to stay credible and sustainable.

Activity 9 — Brand Audit Workshop (Case Study)

Objective: Explain the basics of branding.

Scenario

Nimbus Wellness now has an approved brand concept line from the LU1 attribute-mapping work — but the founder has noticed that the website, the in-store signage and the Instagram bio still each describe the brand slightly differently. Nothing has actually been written down as a standard.

With the 5th-anniversary relaunch three months away, the founder wants one brand-guidelines document that Retail, Marketing and Customer Service can all point to — before a single relaunch asset (banner, caption, staff script) gets produced.

Your table has been asked to draft that guidelines document from the brand concept line Nimbus already approved.

You'll produce

A brand-guidelines document — visual standards, voice guidelines and an implementation roadmap (Duration: 30 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

33. Starting from Nimbus's approved brand concept line, what visual-identity specifications (logo usage, colour palette, typography) actually protect that concept?
34. What brand values and mission statement belong in the guidelines so all three teams can restate them the same way?
35. What does "Nimbus's voice" sound like in a customer email versus an Instagram caption — where should the tone flex, and where must it stay fixed?
36. What is one concrete usage example (a do/don't pair) that would stop the inconsistency the founder has already noticed?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which building block — visual identity, values, voice or usage rules — was hardest for your table to pin down in concrete terms?
- Did your voice guideline actually sound different from a generic "friendly and professional" brand, or could it apply to any wellness company?
- If a new hire in Customer Service only ever read your guidelines document, would they write in Nimbus's voice by the end of week one?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a one-page brand-guidelines draft — visual identity spec, brand values, a voice description with an example, and at least one concrete usage do/don't — that Retail, Marketing and Customer Service could each apply without further clarification.

Activity 10 — Brand-Marketing Audit Exercise (Case Study)

Objective: Explain the role of branding in marketing.

Scenario

The Marketing Lead has just shown your table Nimbus's most recent campaign: a two-week discount push on the best-selling serum, promoted purely on price. It performed well on sales, but the founder is uneasy — it never once mentioned the brand values from the LU1 attribute map, and a few loyal customers commented that it "felt like any other skincare sale."

Before the relaunch campaign is greenlit, leadership wants proof that Nimbus's marketing activity is actually building the brand, not just borrowing short-term attention from it. Your table has been asked to audit the discount campaign against Nimbus's approved brand identity.

You'll produce

A brand-audit report with a consistency assessment and recommendations (Duration: 20 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

37. Which core identity elements from Nimbus's approved brand concept should this campaign have reflected — and which of them actually appeared in the discount push?
38. Was the discount campaign's messaging aligned with the brand's identity, or did it lean on price alone the way a generic competitor would?
39. Where exactly is the gap between what the campaign said and what the brand stands for — and how wide is it?
40. What two or three concrete changes would make the next relaunch-adjacent campaign build brand equity instead of just moving stock?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your table's consistency score match what the loyal-customer comments already hinted at?
- Was the gap you found about the message itself, or about which channel carried it?
- If every future Nimbus campaign scored this low on brand alignment, what would that do to the 5th-anniversary relaunch's credibility?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a brand-audit report with a consistency assessment score for the discount campaign, the specific identity elements that were missing, and two or three concrete recommendations for better brand-marketing integration.

Activity 11 — Brand Activation Planning Workshop (Case Study)

Objective: Execute branding campaigns, events and activities to increase brand awareness.

Scenario

The brand guidelines are drafted and the consistency gaps are named. Now the founder needs an actual activation plan for the 5th-anniversary relaunch — the campaign that has to win back the customers who say Nimbus "doesn't feel personal anymore" while reaching new customers who are comparing Nimbus to the competitor whose viral campaign started this six months ago.

The founder has one non-negotiable: the relaunch needs at least one experiential element, not just another round of social ads — something people can walk into, touch or take part in, and want to share themselves.

Your table's job is to design the channel mix, the core message and that one experiential element, all traceable back to the brand concept and voice Nimbus has already approved.

You'll produce

A campaign-strategy document with timeline, budget allocation and success metrics (Duration: 30 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

41. What is the one core message the relaunch campaign should carry everywhere — and how does it answer the "doesn't feel personal anymore" perception gap directly?
42. Which 3-4 channels (owned, earned, paid) should carry that message, and what does each channel need to do differently to stay true to Nimbus's brand voice?
43. What is your one experiential element, and what makes it relevant, emotionally engaging and genuinely shareable rather than just an expensive photo backdrop?
44. How will you know the activation actually built brand recall, not just short-term foot traffic or impressions?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your experiential idea start from the brand story, or did the brand story get bolted on afterward to justify an idea your table already liked?
- Which channel in your mix was hardest to keep consistent with Nimbus's brand voice, and why?
- If the experiential element only reached 200 people in person, what would have to be true about the rest of your channel mix for the relaunch to still feel successful?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a campaign plan naming 3-4 channels, one core message traceable to the brand concept, one experiential element with a clear rationale, and a brand-recall metric for measuring success — not just a reach or attendance number.

Activity 12 — PR Campaign Budget Planning (Case Study)

Objective: Execute public-relations campaigns in alignment to brand positioning strategies, operational plans and budget.

Scenario

The CEO has approved a bounded PR budget for the 5th-anniversary relaunch — but not a blank cheque. Before a single dollar is spent, the CEO wants to see it allocated across earned, owned and paid channels in a way that visibly matches Nimbus's brand positioning, not just whichever channel the Marketing team finds easiest to book.

The Board has already flagged a second concern for after the relaunch: they want ongoing proof the campaign improved Nimbus's reputation, not just its impression count — so today's budget plan needs KPIs the Board can actually hold the team to.

Your table has been asked to build the PR budget proposal the CEO will sign off on.

You'll produce

A PR budget proposal with channel allocation and success metrics (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

45. Using the PESO model, how should the budget split across paid, earned, shared and owned channels given Nimbus's brand positioning and the perception gap it's trying to close?
46. Which channel deserves the largest share of spend for this specific relaunch — and which would you deliberately underfund, and why?
47. What percentage, if any, should be held back as a reserve fund, and what would trigger Nimbus to actually spend it?
48. What KPIs would let the Board judge reputation improvement, not just reach or impressions?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your allocation favour the channel that's easiest to execute, or the one the brand positioning actually calls for?
- How did you decide the size of the reserve fund — was it a rule of thumb or tied to a specific risk Nimbus is facing?
- If the Board rejected your KPI list as "just vanity metrics," what would you replace them with?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a PR budget proposal with a percentage split across paid, earned, shared and owned channels, a stated reserve fund, and a KPI list the Board could use to judge reputation impact rather than reach alone.

LU4 — Branding Effectiveness

Reputation Metrics · Success Indicators · PR Tactics · KPI Monitoring · Continuous Improvement

Key concepts

- Reputation is measured through social metrics, digital metrics (traffic, mentions) and business KPIs (NPS, satisfaction) across every platform the organisation touches.
- Successful branding shows up in awareness, customer loyalty, financial impact and trust metrics — tracked consistently over time, not measured once.
- Public-relations tactics — media relations, community outreach, crisis management and digital engagement — extend the brand's message beyond paid channels.
- Monitoring the brand against SMART KPIs and acting on the gaps turns brand management into a continuous-improvement cycle rather than a one-off campaign.

Activity 13 — Platform Reputation Audit (Case Study)

Objective: Identify measures or indicators of the organisation's reputation on different platforms.

Scenario

Three weeks after Nimbus Wellness's 5th-anniversary relaunch went live, the founder is celebrating a spike in impressions and website traffic. The Board isn't satisfied with raw numbers, though — it wants to know whether the relaunch actually repaired the "doesn't feel personal anymore" perception gap uncovered before the campaign, or just produced a short-term spike in attention.

Marketing has a folder of screenshots — likes, shares, a handful of glowing reviews — but no one has compared this to what reputation looked like before the relaunch, or checked the platforms customers actually complain on, like Google reviews and the wellness retail chain's own app.

Before Marketing reports back to the Board next week, your table must build the audit that separates real reputation movement from relaunch-week noise.

You'll produce

A platform-by-platform reputation audit (3+ platforms) with leading and lagging indicators tracked, and a leadership-ready read on whether the relaunch actually shifted reputation (Duration: 20 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

49. Which 3 platforms will actually tell you whether Nimbus's reputation has shifted since the relaunch — not just which platforms have the most impressions?

50. Which of your chosen metrics are leading indicators that warn of a problem early, and which are lagging indicators that only confirm what already happened?
51. How would you separate a genuine sentiment shift on "feels personal again" from a short-term spike caused by relaunch hype alone?
52. What would you tell the Board next week if the quantitative numbers looked good but the qualitative comments never mentioned feeling more "personal" at all?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your table lean too heavily on quantitative metrics before someone asked what the qualitative comments actually said?
- Which platform did you almost leave out of the audit — and why did it turn out to matter?
- If the relaunch metrics stay strong for one more month and then fade, what would that suggest about whether the reputation gap was really closed?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a platform-by-platform audit naming at least one leading and one lagging indicator per platform, and can state in one sentence whether the evidence shows a genuine reputation shift or just a relaunch-week spike.

Activity 14 — Brand Health Assessment (Case Study)

Objective: Recognise the indicators of successful branding.

Scenario

The Board's real question isn't "did the relaunch get noticed" — it's whether Nimbus's brand is genuinely healthier than it was six months ago. Marketing has awareness numbers on hand, but no one has looked at loyalty, financial impact or trust together.

The founder is due to present a "State of the Brand" update to the Board in two weeks, right after the relaunch's first full sales cycle closes. She has asked your table for a one-page brand-health scorecard she can defend line by line.

Customer Service has also noticed something odd: several long-time customers who complained the brand "feels distant" are now leaving five-star reviews again — but repeat-purchase data hasn't moved yet.

You'll produce

A brand-health scorecard across all four pillars (Awareness, Loyalty, Financial Impact, Trust) with evidence and one improvement action for the weakest pillar (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

53. Across Awareness, Loyalty, Financial Impact and Trust, which pillar is Nimbus strongest on right now, and which is weakest — and what evidence would prove it either way?
54. The reviews have improved but repeat-purchase data hasn't moved — which pillar does that gap sit in, and what does it tell the founder about how long a real recovery actually takes?
55. If you could only fund one more month of measurement in a single pillar, which would move the Board's confidence most, and why?
56. What separates a brand-health indicator the Board should act on immediately from one that's just worth watching?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which pillar did your table find hardest to find real evidence for — awareness, loyalty, financial impact or trust?
- Did the group's instinct about Nimbus's strongest pillar match what the evidence actually showed?
- If financial impact keeps lagging the other three pillars for another quarter, is that a marketing problem or an operations problem?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show a one-page scorecard rating Nimbus on all four pillars with named evidence for each rating, plus one improvement action for the weakest pillar.

Activity 15 — PR Crisis Response Plan (Role Play)

Objective: Apply public-relations tactics.

Scenario

It's 9pm, the night before the founder's biggest relaunch media interview yet. A customer posts a video of her new Nimbus jar — from the new sustainable packaging line launched with the anniversary campaign — cracked and leaking product, captioned "the 'eco-friendly' packaging Nimbus is so proud of." Within two hours it has hundreds of shares and a wave of other customers replying with their own photos.

Operations thinks it may be a single bad batch from the new packaging supplier, but can't confirm numbers until morning. The journalist doing tomorrow's interview has already seen the thread and has emailed asking whether Nimbus knew about a defect before launch.

The founder wants to say nothing until Operations has the full facts — but the thread is growing every hour, and tomorrow's interview is unavoidable. Your group must decide what Nimbus does tonight, and what the spokesperson says tomorrow morning.

You'll produce

A same-night crisis-response script (public statement + next-day interview line) rehearsed through the three roles, benchmarked against a real 2024-2025 crisis example (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Roles

Assign one role per participant (or per small group):

- **Spokesperson** — *Goal: Represent Nimbus publicly without over-promising.* Must decide what Nimbus can credibly say before every fact is confirmed, and how much to reveal in tomorrow's interview.
- **Journalist** — *Goal: Get a real, on-record answer for tomorrow's story.* Already has screenshots of the complaint thread and will ask directly whether Nimbus knew about the packaging issue before the relaunch.
- **Crisis-Response Lead** — *Goal: Coordinate the facts and the fix before Nimbus says anything publicly.* Is still confirming with Operations exactly how many units are affected, and whether it's a supplier fault or a Nimbus quality-control miss.

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

57. Is staying silent until Operations confirms every fact actually the safer choice tonight, or does it leave a vacuum the thread will fill for Nimbus?
58. What can the Spokesperson honestly commit to in tomorrow's interview before the root cause is even confirmed?
59. How should the Crisis-Response Lead's internal fact-finding and the Spokesperson's public statement stay in sync without one getting ahead of the other?
60. What would Nimbus need to say and do in the first 24 hours to be judged as fast and transparent rather than defensive?

Reflect & Discuss

- Did your Spokesperson end up promising more, or less, than Nimbus could actually deliver by morning?
- Where did the Journalist's questions expose a gap between what the Crisis-Response Lead knew and what the Spokesperson said?
- Looking at the Cracker Barrel and McDonald's examples, which pattern did your group's response end up closer to — and was that a deliberate choice?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can perform or narrate a same-night response that names what Nimbus confirms publicly within hours, what it says in tomorrow's interview, and a follow-up commitment — and can point to which real-world example (fast/transparent vs delayed/silent) their plan resembles.

Activity 16 — KPI Dashboard Design (Case Study)

Objective: Monitor the success of the brand against Key Performance Indicators (KPI).

Scenario

The Board's ask is specific: it wants a KPI framework it can check every month after the relaunch, not a one-off report from Marketing whenever someone remembers to send it. The founder, who is not a numbers person, has asked for something she can read in five minutes and still trust.

Right now every department tracks something different — Marketing watches follower counts, Retail watches footfall, Customer Service watches response times — and none of it is compared against a target or a deadline. Last month someone reported "engagement is up" without saying up from what, or by when it should keep rising.

Your table's job is to turn this scattered activity into a small set of SMART KPIs the Board can actually govern the relaunch by.

You'll produce

A SMART KPI framework (3 internal + 3 external KPIs) with an owner, target, data source and review deadline for each (Duration: 20 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

61. Which 3 internal and 3 external KPIs would actually tell the Board whether the relaunch is working — not just which numbers are easiest for each department to pull?
62. Take one of your KPIs through the full SMART test — where does it break down first, and how do you fix that?
63. Who owns each KPI, and what happens if the number misses target two months in a row?
64. If the Board can only look at one dashboard slide, what's the smallest set of numbers that still tells the whole story?

Reflect & Discuss

- Which of your KPIs was hardest to make genuinely Measurable rather than just a description of activity?

- Did your table set a target that was Attainable, or did ambition win out over realism?
- If one KPI is red for two straight months, does your framework actually say what happens next — or does it stop at reporting the number?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can show 3 internal + 3 external KPIs, each SMART-tested with a named owner, target, data source and review deadline, and can explain what action a missed target would trigger.

Activity 17 — PR Campaign Audit Exercise (Case Study)

Objective: Provide suggestions to improve public-relations campaign effectiveness.

Scenario

It's now two months after the 5th-anniversary relaunch. The Board has seen the KPI dashboard designed in the last activity, and the numbers are mixed: impressions are up sharply, but the "doesn't feel personal anymore" sentiment has only partly recovered, and one retail partner is still hesitant to expand shelf space.

The founder wants one final audit before she reports to the Board — not a scorecard of what Nimbus did, but a verdict on whether the relaunch campaign actually worked, and three concrete recommendations for what happens next.

This is the same audit the Board will expect Nimbus to repeat after every future campaign — so your table isn't just closing out the relaunch, it's building the habit the brand will run on going forward.

You'll produce

An AMEC-based campaign audit (Inputs/Outputs/Outcomes/Impact) with three stage-specific recommendations for the next campaign (Duration: 25 minutes.)

Discussion & Decision Prompts

Work through these together — there is no single correct order to follow:

65. Run the relaunch campaign through AMEC's Inputs → Outputs → Outcomes → Impact chain — at which stage does the evidence get weakest?
66. Impressions are up but the "feels personal" sentiment has only partly recovered — is that an Outputs success but an Outcomes failure, or something else?
67. What would you tell the founder is the single biggest gap between what Nimbus measured and what the Board actually needed to know?
68. What three recommendations would you make for the next campaign, and which AMEC stage does each one fix?

Reflect & Discuss

- Looking back across all five LU4 activities, which measurement habit would have caught today's gap earliest — the reputation audit, the brand-health scorecard, or the KPI dashboard?
- Did your table's recommendations fix the root cause, or just add another metric to track?
- If Nimbus only adopts one habit from this whole course to run every future campaign by, what should it be?

Debrief it

Check: Every group can map the relaunch campaign to all four AMEC stages (Inputs, Outputs, Outcomes, Impact), name the weakest stage with evidence, and give three recommendations that each fix a different stage — not three versions of the same idea.

Quick Reference — Activities by Learning Unit

Learning Unit	Activity	Duration
LU1	1. Stakeholder Influence Mapping	25 minutes
LU1	2. Audience Mapping Workshop	25 minutes
LU1	3. Brand Attribute Mapping	30 minutes
LU1	4. Digital Reputation Audit Exercise	45 minutes
LU2	5. Brand Perception Audit	25 minutes
LU2	6. Brand Advocacy Assessment	25 minutes
LU2	7. Campaign Documentation Audit	25 minutes
LU2	8. Customer Perspective Analysis	25 minutes
LU3	9. Brand Audit Workshop	30 minutes
LU3	10. Brand-Marketing Audit Exercise	20 minutes
LU3	11. Brand Activation Planning Workshop	30 minutes
LU3	12. PR Campaign Budget Planning	25 minutes
LU4	13. Platform Reputation Audit	20 minutes
LU4	14. Brand Health Assessment	25 minutes
LU4	15. PR Crisis Response Plan	25 minutes
LU4	16. KPI Dashboard Design	20 minutes
LU4	17. PR Campaign Audit Exercise	25 minutes

Assessment

- Written Assessment (WA) — Short-Answer Questions (SAQ), 1 hour, open book.
- Case Study (CS) — one continuous branding scenario with open-ended tasks, 1 hour, open book.
- Format: Open Book — this Learner Guide, the course slides and approved materials only.
- Grading: Competent / Not Yet Competent.
- A minimum of 75% attendance (per SSG Digital Attendance record) is required to be eligible for assessment and funding. Learners must be assessed as Competent and complete the TRAQOM survey.

Assessment Flow

1. TRAQOM — scan the TRAQOM QR code on the LMS and complete the survey.
2. Assessment Digital Attendance.
3. Assessment (Written Assessment + Case Study).
4. Submit the assessment answers on the LMS.
5. Sign the Assessment Summary Record.

Courseware and the assessment are on the LMS: <https://lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com/>

Glossary

- **Brand positioning** — The distinct place a brand occupies in the customer's mind relative to competitors.
- **Stakeholder** — Any internal or external party with an interest in, or influence over, the brand.
- **Active listening** — Giving full attention, applying a structured framework, and paraphrasing without judgement.
- **Brand equity** — The commercial value derived from consumer perception of the brand, not the product itself.
- **KPI** — Key Performance Indicator — a specific, measurable metric used to judge progress against a goal.
- **AMEC framework** — An industry framework for measuring and evaluating PR / communication campaign effectiveness.
- **NPS** — Net Promoter Score — a customer-loyalty metric based on likelihood to recommend the brand.
- **TRAQOM** — The SSG post-course survey completed via the LMS, distinct from digital attendance.

Support

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